

**OPEN CHALLENGE** Andhra Pradesh Congress president Y.S. Sharmila campaigning in Visakhapatnam, April 28

vaneswari, the third daughter of TDP founder N.T. Rama Rao (NTR), launched the 'Nijam Gelavali' (Truth Should Triumph) tour on October 25, 2023 from Chandragiri in Tirupati district. The purpose was to console the families of TDP sympathisers who had reportedly died, "unable to bear the illegal arrest" of Naidu. Bhuvaneswari met 203 bereaved families and offered financial help. That Bhuvaneswari—who has so far kept a low profile, managing the Naidu family's Heritage Foods Ltd business—decided to step out is being seen as a last-ditch attempt by her husband to wrest power. The Nijam Gelavali tour took Bhuvaneswari through 95 assembly constituencies across all 25 Lok Sabha constituencies before her tour concluded on April 13. To consolidate the gains from the tours by Bhuvaneswari and Lokesh, Naidu began the 'Praja Galam' (Voice of the People) campaign on March 6. By all accounts, he has made the most of it, conducting roadshows and addressing rallies till late in the evening.

Realising early that the TDP may not be able to defeat YSRCP on its own, Naidu has since last summer cultivated an alliance with the BJP and the JSP, though it was announced this March. For 2024, the TDP has kept a major share of the seats—144 assembly seats and 17 LS constituencies—for itself, handing out only 31 assembly and eight LS seats to its allies.

**THE ABSENCE OF COORDINATION BETWEEN THE TDP, BJP AND JSP HAS MADE TRANSFER OF VOTES AMONG THE ALLIES SEEM LIKE A MIRAGE**

## NDA Blues

But not all is going well for the alliance. Analysts say that it suffers from an absence of a concerted effort by the three, which could undo NDA plans at the constituency level and in booth management. Inter-party differences rose to the surface too, with the BJP demonstrating publicly on April 30 against the alliance's common manifesto. The saffron party is also angry with Naidu and Pawan Kalyan for not featuring PM Modi's image and cutouts prominently during their campaigns.

Add to this the absence of coordination among the three parties, which has made transfer of votes seem like a mirage. There were other discordant notes too. While Naidu assured four per cent reservation for Muslims, Union home minister Amit Shah has stated that the BJP was against the very idea—reason enough for Muslim voters to shift towards the YSRCP.

Protesting the disbursal of social security pensions—around 6.5 million people get welfare pensions amounting to Rs 2,000 crore a month—saying it can affect voter behaviour has also boomeranged on the TDP. The Election Commission of India has now stepped in, clearing the state's payments due in May to beneficiary bank accounts. A staggering 96.7 per cent of Rs 1,945 crore to 6.54 million pensioners was disbursed to beneficiaries in the first two days of May itself. Those who did not get pensions through direct bank transfers were paid through the village and ward secretariat system. To be sure, it is advantage YSRCP here.

Political analysts believe that in a head-to-head contest between the YSRCP and the TDP, Jagan retains the edge. "The YSRCP social base was broadened through mass contact and welfare programmes, which would have cut into the TDP voter base among the poor," says Vageeshan. However, an undercurrent of anti-incumbency, along with the perception of corruption in governance, may whittle down the YSRCP's prospects. The CM, though, has played his hand intelligently. As social commentator A.M. Khan Yazdani puts it: "Despite signs of anti-incumbency, Jagan has won the trust of his Reddy community even as he implemented schemes for the needy." On May 13, Andhra's voters will choose between Jagan's slew of efficiently delivered welfare measures and Naidu's charges of corruption and appeals for a last chance. Expect a fight to the finish. ■